MBAI 5400G: Visualization and Storytelling

Assignment 2 - Redesigning John Snow's Cholera Map

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Iteration 1:
For my first iteration, my thought process was to replace the traditional points and bars used in the original visualization with more intuitive visual symbols. Instead of simple markers, I introduced recognizable images to represent key elements of the map.

I used a water pump icon to represent the locations of public pumps and skeleton icons to represent recorded cholera deaths.

Iteration 2: In my initial redesign, I used skeleton icons to represent deaths. However, after reflecting on this choice, I felt that skeletons also did not feel very human-centered and could appear insensitive. Each point on the map represents a real person and family affected during the outbreak, so I wanted a symbol that communicated that more respectfully.

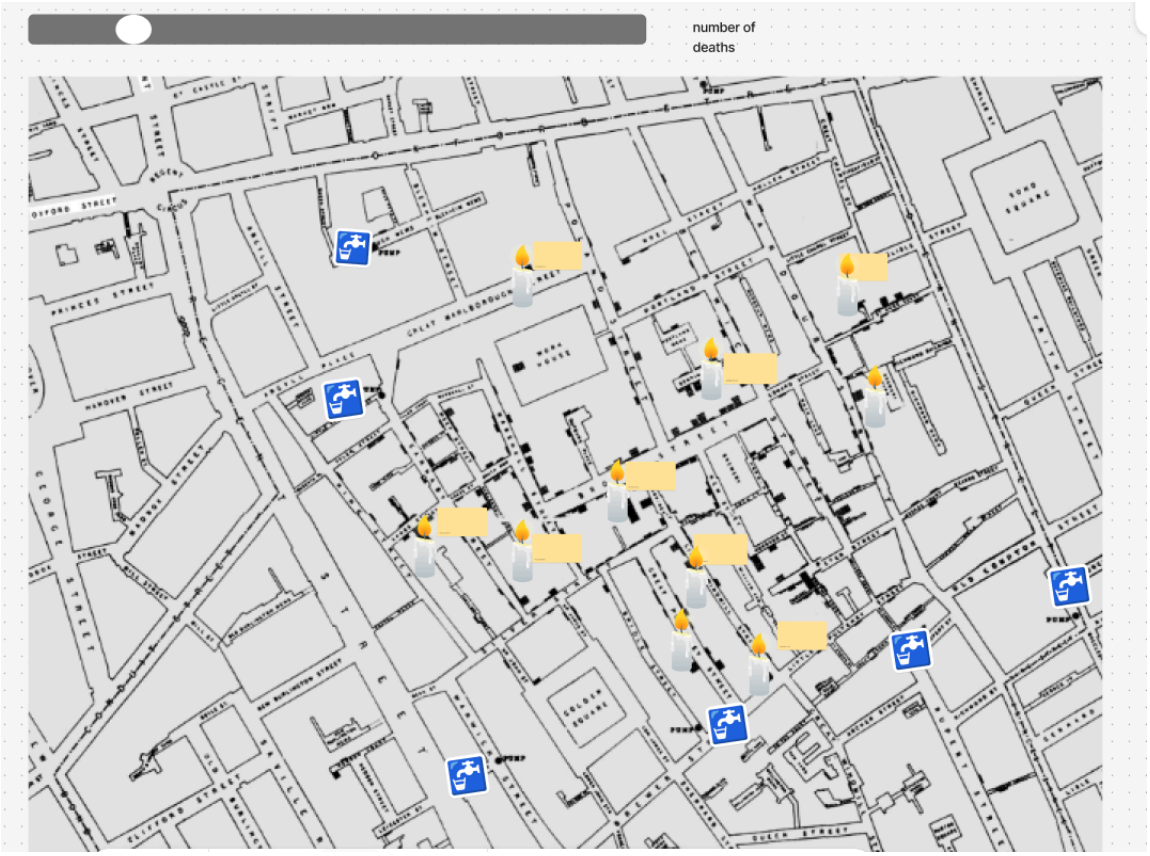
For my next iteration, I decided to replace the skeleton icons with candle lights. The candle symbol acts as a quiet memorial, representing remembrance and honoring the individuals who lost their lives during the 1854 Broad Street cholera outbreak.

Iteration 3:

For my final iteration, I wanted the visualization to be more than something viewers simply look at. I wanted it to be interactive so users could explore the data and better understand the spread of the outbreak. To achieve this, I added a time slider that allows viewers to see how the cholera deaths appeared and spread over time.

I also included interactive tooltips. When viewers hover over the candle icons, they can see additional information such as the distance from the outbreak source and how many people died at that specific address according to the available data.

After my first iteration, I realized that one of the common critiques of the original map by John Snow is that the bars used to represent deaths did not feel very human-centered. They reduced the lives lost during the outbreak to abstract marks rather than representing real people.


number of deaths
OXFORD STREET
PRINCES STREET
HANOVER STREET
GREAT MARLBOROUGH STREET
GOLDEN SQUARE
SOHO SQUARE
QUEEN STREET
GEORGE STREET
CLIFFORD STREET
NEW BURLINGTON STREET
REGENT STREET